Check for updates

Received: 30 September 2024 | Revised: 19 August 2025 | Accepted: 5 September 2025

DOI: 10.1111/asap.70037

ORIGINAL ARTICLE

asap Analyses of Social Issues and Public Policy SPSSI WILEY

Living in fear: The psychological impact of the threat of sexual violence on women in India

Afreen Waseem[1] | **Naila Firdous**[2] | **Shah Alam**[2]

[1]Department of Applied Psychology, GITAM University, Hyderabad, Telangana, India

[2]Department of Psychology, Aligarh Muslim University, Aligarh, Uttar Pradesh, India

Correspondence
Afreen Waseem, Department of Applied Psychology, GITAM University, Hyderabad, Telangana, India.
Email: afreenwaseem800@gmail.com

Abstract

In today's society, women are increasingly vulnerable to sexual violence, whether at home, in the workplace, or in public spaces. This study aims to explore how the perceived threat of sexual violence affects the psychological well-being and daily behavior of women aged 20–30 in northern India, with a focus on fear, stress, and anxiety. A qualitative approach was employed, using semi-structured interviews with a purposive sample of 20 women. Data were collected through text-based online interviews, and thematic analysis was performed to identify key patterns and insights related to the psychological impact of sexual violence. Based on Trauma Theory, Cognitive Processing Theory, and feminist perspectives, the findings revealed that the fear of sexual violence led to heightened stress and anxiety, significantly affecting participants' mental well-being. Many women reported behavioral changes such as avoiding certain locations and altering daily routines to stay safe. The study highlighted the role of societal norms and family pressures in shaping how women deal with these threats. This study also underscores the urgent need for mental health support for women coping with the psychological toll of sexual violence.

This is an open access article under the terms of the Creative Commons Attribution-NonCommercial-NoDerivs License, which permits use and distribution in any medium, provided the original work is properly cited, the use is non-commercial and no modifications or adaptations are made.
© 2025 The Author(s). *Analyses of Social Issues and Public Policy* published by Wiley Periodicals LLC on behalf of Society for the Psychological Study of Social Issues.

KEYWORDS
anxiety, fear, harassment, psychological impact, sexual violence, stress

Public Significance Statement

This paper shows how fear of sexual violence affects women's daily routines, social life, and job opportunities. It urges society to educate men to respect and live safely with women, encourages bystanders to support women in need, and calls for government initiatives to create safe spaces where women can move freely without the threat of violence, abuse, or any form of attack.

INTRODUCTION

In recent decades, India has witnessed a significant transformation in women's roles across education, employment, and public life. Women are increasingly visible in professional spaces, civic leadership, and higher education, reflecting ongoing efforts to address gender disparities (Chatterjee, 2020). However, this progress has not been without resistance. The rising presence of women in public spheres has coincided with a persistent and often intensifying threat of sexual violence (Bhattacharyya, 2016; Sharma & Gupta, 2020). Feminist scholars argue that this is not coincidental but reflects a broader sociological pattern of backlash. Sylvia Walby's (1990) concept of public patriarchy theorizes how patriarchal control has transitioned from the domestic (private) to the public domain, wherein social norms and institutional structures seek to regulate and restrain women's freedom in visible, collective spaces.

In the Indian context, such patriarchal backlash often takes the form of implicit and explicit threats of sexual violence, which serve to regulate women's behavior under the guise of protection (Phadke, 2007). While women have made notable achievements in education, employment, and civic participation, these gains are often weakened by a climate of fear that curtails their agency (Desai & Andrist, 2010). The psychological consequences of this ambient threat, though profound, remain underexamined in the Indian scenario.

While global literature has increasingly turned toward the psychological burden of living among women under threat, particularly in post-conflict, urban, or patriarchal societies, there remains a critical lack of such scholarship focused on India (Kalokhe et al., 2015). Some important contributions do exist, particularly in the feminist psychological analyses of gender and violence by Indian scholars. For example, Vindhya (2020) in Battered Conjugality explored the psychological consequences of domestic violence, and her review provides an overview of feminist psychological research in India. However, Indian academic discourse frequently overlooks the more subtle but no less significant psychological effects that the mere expectation of violence may trigger, rather than highlighting the socio-legal and physical manifestations of gender-based violence. This absence in psychological literature neglects how fear becomes a chronic psychological state, altering women's internal cognitive and emotional landscapes long before, and often without, any physical event occurring.

15302415, 2025, 3, Downloaded from https://spssi.onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/asap.70037, Wiley Online Library on [19/01/2026]. See the Terms and Conditions (https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/terms-and-conditions) on Wiley Online Library for rules of use; OA articles are governed by the applicable Creative Commons License

To understand these dynamics, the present study draws on Trauma Theory (Herman, 1992), Cognitive Processing Theory (Resick & Schnicke, 1992), and feminist frameworks to explore how internalized fear functions not just as an emotional state but as a mechanism of social control. The paper further contributes to the literature by theorizing how gendered fear shapes space, safety, and agency in the Indian sociocultural context. This study also investigates how the anticipation and fear of sexual violence, as not necessarily its direct experience, affects women's mental health, restricts their behaviors, and reinforces societal structures that limit their autonomy. In India, widespread concerns about gender-based violence have given rise to a culture of fear among women, particularly in urban and semi-urban contexts (Phadke, 2007). While media and legal discourse often focus on incidents of actual sexual violence, less attention has been given to the psychological toll of its persistent threat (Bhattacharyya, 2016; Kalokhe et al., 2015).

The use of the term sexual violence in this paper refers specifically to women's perception and fear of potential acts of sexual aggression in public and private spaces. It does not imply that participants were direct victims of such violence, but rather that the ongoing threat serves as a powerful psychological and behavioral constraint (Phadke,2007). This framing distinguishes the study from trauma research based solely on post-assault effects and redirects attention to how fear alone can function as a systemic form of oppression (Pryor & Hughes, 2013).

Sexual violence has a profound psychological impact on women, often leading to pervasive fear, anxiety, and long-lasting trauma. A study by Hanson (1990) focus on the psychological effects of actual experiences of assault, the emotional markers they identify, such as chronic fear, anxiety, and cognitive disruption, are also evident in women living under the persistent threat of such violence. These psychological parallels underscore the need to understand anticipatory trauma, even in the absence of direct victimization (Souza et al., 2012). These psychological effects manifest in various ways, such as persistent fear of public spaces, social withdrawal, and a heightened sense of vulnerability in their daily lives (Antonsdóttir, 2020). Many women alter their behavior to avoid perceived threats, such as avoiding specific locations, changing their routines, and becoming hypervigilant to potential dangers (Nieder et al., 2019) This constant state of alertness and fear significantly affects their overall well-being and quality of life (Amone-P'Olak et al., 2018; Quing, 2021).

India, the prevalence of sexual violence has reached alarming levels, with incidents continuing to rise despite legal reforms and public awareness campaigns. The National Crime Records Bureau (NCRB) reported over 32,000 cases of rape in 2021 alone, highlighting the pervasive nature of sexual violence in the country (Kumar & Parkash, 2020). This number, however, is likely just the tip of the iceberg, as many cases go unreported due to fear of social stigma, victim-blaming, and lack of trust in the legal system (Mcdonald & Martinez, 2019). The psychological impact on victims is profound, leading to chronic fear, anxiety, depression, and in severe cases, post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD) (Moscarello, 1990). These mental health issues are further exacerbated by societal norms that often place the burden of shame on the victim rather than the perpetrator, leading to isolation, low self-esteem, and in some cases, suicidal tendencies (Nolin et al., 2023). Recent high-profile cases of sexual violence in India, such as the 2012 Delhi gang rape and the Hathras gang rape, have garnered national and international attention, highlighting deep-seated issues of caste, gender, and violence. The Delhi gang rape, often referred to as the Nirbhaya case, sparked widespread protests and led to legal reforms aimed at strengthening women's rights and the criminal justice system. However, despite these changes, sexual violence remains a critical issue. The Hathras gang rape case in 2020 further underscored the intersectionality of caste, gender, and violence, as the victim, a young Dalit woman, was brutally assaulted and later died from

15302415, 2025, 3, Downloaded from https://spssi.onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/asap.70037, Wiley Online Library on [19/01/2026]. See the Terms and Conditions (https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/terms-and-conditions) on Wiley Online Library for rules of use; OA articles are governed by the applicable Creative Commons License

her injuries. The case also highlighted systemic failures, including allegations of a cover-up by local authorities, which fueled public outrage and demands for justice (Tripathi, 2023).

The fear and anxiety experienced by women in response to incidents of sexual violence are deeply ingrained in their daily lives, particularly in urban areas of India. Studies have shown that this pervasive fear leads to significant behavioral changes as women adopt various strategies to protect themselves. For instance, many women in Delhi report taking extreme precautions, such as avoiding certain areas, limiting their movements, or only traveling in groups, especially at night (Nieder et al., 2019). These strategies are not just rational responses to potential threats but also reflect the deep psychological impact that these incidents have on women, affecting their sense of safety and autonomy (Riger & Gordon, 1981).

Recent studies underscore the pervasive impact that the fear of sexual violence has on the behavior and decisions of women in India, particularly when it comes to traveling alone at night, using public transportation, working night shifts, living alone, and accepting jobs far from home. For instance, recent research highlights how the fear of sexual assault in public spaces, exacerbated by high-profile incidents and societal attitudes, severely restricts women's mobility (Ison et al., 2023). This fear compels many women to avoid traveling alone at night, and when they do, they often take extensive precautions, such as choosing safer routes, avoiding isolated areas, or using only trusted modes of transportation (Stark & Meschik, 2018)

Similarly, studies on women working night shifts reveal that despite safety measures provided by employers, such as company-arranged transportation, many women continue to feel unsafe during their commutes. It is found that women working in the call center industry in Mumbai frequently experience fear and anxiety related to their night shifts. These women often have to navigate the dual stigmas of being out late at night and the constant threat of sexual violence, which forces them to adopt strict safety routines and limits their sense of freedom and autonomy (Parikh, 2018).

The impact of sexual violence extends beyond immediate safety concerns, influencing broader life choices such as living arrangements and job opportunities. Research indicates that many women opt to live with family or in secure, well-monitored housing complexes to mitigate the risk of being targeted if they live alone. This choice is often driven by the fear of sexual violence, which shapes not only where women choose to live but also how they engage with their communities (Nieder et al., 2019).

Public transportation is another critical area where the fear of sexual violence impacts women's daily lives. A study reveals that incidents of sexual harassment on public transport are alarmingly common, leading many women to avoid traveling alone, especially at night, or to take drastic precautions if they must use public transport. This constant vigilance not only adds to women's mental burden but also restricts their mobility and independence (Huang et al., 2023)

Another area significantly impacted by the pervasive fear of sexual violence in India is women's participation in outdoor and recreational activities. Recent studies show that the anxiety surrounding potential sexual assault severely limits women's engagement in public leisure spaces, such as parks, beaches, and other outdoor recreational areas. This fear is particularly acute in urban environments where incidents of harassment and violence are more frequently reported. Another recent study in Delhi found that women are increasingly cautious about attending public events and participating in cultural activities due to safety concerns. This study highlighted that the fear of sexual violence leads to a significant reduction in social engagement, with many women preferring to stay indoors or only attend events where they can ensure their safety through group participation or other measures. The study emphasized that this behavior not only limits

15302415, 2025, 3, Downloaded from https://spssi.onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/asap.70037, Wiley Online Library on [19/01/2026]. See the Terms and Conditions (https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/terms-and-conditions) on Wiley Online Library for rules of use; OA articles are governed by the applicable Creative Commons License

women's access to cultural and social life but also contributes to feelings of isolation and stress, negatively affecting their mental health (Nieder et al., 2019).

Recent studies and reports have highlighted the severe impact of the fear of sexual violence on women's daily lives in rural areas of India, particularly in states like Uttar Pradesh (UP). In these regions, according to the National Crime Records Bureau (NCRB), Uttar Pradesh (UP) reported the highest number of cases of crimes against women in 2022, with 65,743 FIRs registered The other states with the highest incidence of crimes against women in 2022 included Maharashtra with 45,331 cases, Rajasthan with 45,058 cases, West Bengal with 34,738 cases, and Madhya Pradesh with 32,765 cases (Pooja et al., 2024). The combination of these factors creates a vicious cycle where the fear of sexual violence leads to reduced opportunities for women, which in turn reinforces their dependence on male family members and limits their ability to achieve economic and social independence (Mehra et al., 2023).

Building on insights from recent studies, this research seeks to explore the psychological impact of the fear, anxiety, and stress of sexual violence on women, particularly in the most affected regions like Uttar Pradesh and the New Delhi NCR (Rai & Rai, 2020). As the rising cases of sexual abuse exacerbate anxiety and stress, they severely constrain women's freedom, mobility, and opportunities for economic and social independence (Pryor & Hughes, 2013). This study explores how the perceived threat of sexual violence impacts Indian women's psychological state and common behavior in urban and semi-urban settings, based on gaps in the literature and the growing psychological burden among Indian women (Banerjea, 2019) Despite an increasing number of studies on the prevalence of sexual violence in India, there remains a significant gap in understanding its psychological consequences, particularly the fear, anxiety, and behavioral restrictions it imposes on women in their everyday lives. Most existing literature has focused on legal reforms, incidence rates, or physical consequences, with relatively less emphasis on the lived psychological experiences of women, especially in urban and semi-urban settings like Delhi NCR and Uttar Pradesh. This study addresses that gap by examining how the perceived threat of sexual violence shapes women's mental health, alters their behavior, and reinforces societal limitations on autonomy (Kalokhe et al., 2015). By foregrounding women's voices and experiences through qualitative inquiry, this research contributes to a deeper and more contextualized understanding of the emotional and social toll of living under constant fear.

MATERIALS AND METHODS

Research design

A qualitative approach was utilized to explore how the perceived threat of sexual violence affects psychological well-being and daily behavior among women.

Study setting

The study focused on women aged 20–30 living in Delhi NCR and Uttar Pradesh. These areas were chosen due to the alarming rise in sexual abuse cases and the significant impact of this violence on women's psychological well-being.

15302415, 2025, 3, Downloaded from https://spssi.onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/asap.70037, Wiley Online Library on [19/01/2026]. See the Terms and Conditions (https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/terms-and-conditions) on Wiley Online Library for rules of use; OA articles are governed by the applicable Creative Commons License

Participants

Participants were recruited through social media channels, where they voluntarily responded to participate in the research. The inclusion criteria ensured that participants had either directly or indirectly experienced fear, anxiety, or stress related to sexual violence. The study involved 20 women aged between 20 and 30 years, residing in urban and semi-urban areas across Delhi NCR and Uttar Pradesh regions. All participants held at least a bachelor's degree: 12 had completed undergraduate degrees, 10 held master's degrees, and 5 had attained doctoral or higher qualifications. The participants were employed across a range of professional sectors, including education (8 participants), technology (7 participants), social work (6 participants), and the service industry (6 participants). The interviews were conducted remotely using WhatsApp or Google Docs, based on each participant's preference, to accommodate privacy and convenience. All interviews were conducted by the first author, a female researcher trained in trauma psychology and gender-based violence, who shares the cultural and geographical background of the participants. This positional similarity facilitated trust and openness during data collection, while also requiring reflexivity to minimize the influence of academic privilege on the interpretation of participants' experiences. Simultaneously, the researcher maintained reflexivity throughout the study process by keeping analytic memos, expressing opinion on potential biases, and discussing coding decisions with colleagues to ensure that personal assumptions did not disproportionately influence data interpretation. The researcher's same gender and cultural background increased empathy and sensitivity, but she was also acutely aware of her academic position and privilege, especially when working with participants from different socioeconomic strata. This positionality allowed for ensuring participants' voices were represented authentically and not filtered through the researcher's own experiences.

Inclusion and exclusion criteria

Participants were eligible for inclusion if they self-identified as women, were aged between 20 and 30 years, and resided in Delhi NCR and Uttar Pradesh regions of India. They were also required to have at least a bachelor's degree and be actively engaged in education or employment, as the study focused on women who regularly travel to public spaces. Individuals were excluded if they reported having experienced indirect sexual violence, as the research focused specifically on the psychological impact of the perceived threat of sexual violence, rather than the aftermath of actual incidents. Participants who were not comfortable communicating via text-based platforms or lacked the technological means to do so were also excluded.

Data collection

Data were collected through semi-structured, text-based interviews conducted online in August/2024. A text-based format was chosen for the study. To ensure the comfort and anonymity of participants discussing sensitive and potentially traumatic experiences. The interviews were conducted primarily in English and Hindi, depending on each participant's language preference. Most women chose to respond in English, but five participants opted for Hindi. Where necessary, Hindi responses were translated into English prior to analysis using a combination of manual

15302415, 2025, 3, Downloaded from https://spssi.onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/asap.70037, Wiley Online Library on [19/01/2026]. See the Terms and Conditions (https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/terms-and-conditions) on Wiley Online Library for rules of use; OA articles are governed by the applicable Creative Commons License

translation and back-translation for accuracy. All responses were copied and stored as Word documents for transcription and later imported into qualitative analysis software for coding and thematic analysis. Sample questions included:

1. How do you perceive the current situation regarding sexual violence in India?
2. Have you or someone you know ever experienced sexual violence? If so, how has this affected you?

All participants were interviewed via WhatsApp and Google Docs, depending on their preferred mode of communication. Participants were recruited through posts on social media groups and academic networks. No monetary compensation was offered; however, participants were acknowledged for their time and emotional labor in the informed consent form and were given access to mental health resources if needed. On average, each interview took approximately 45–60 minutes to complete. Participants were asked open-ended questions about their psychological experiences and how the threat of sexual violence impacted their daily routines, social interactions, and mental health. The questions were carefully designed based on an extensive literature review, focusing on the psychological impact of sexual violence, fear, and coping mechanisms. These questions aimed to explore participants' experiences with sexual violence, how it influenced their daily lives, and how they coped with the emotional problems.

Data analysis

This study used thematic analysis to interpret the data collected from text-based interviews. Thematic analysis was chosen due to its flexibility in identifying, analyzing, and reporting patterns across qualitative data, especially in emotionally sensitive contexts such as the psychological consequences of sexual violence. The analysis followed Braun and Clarke's (2019) six-step framework: familiarization with the data, generating initial codes, searching for themes, reviewing themes, defining and naming themes, and writing up the results. The data were analyzed using ATLAS.ti, a qualitative data analysis software that allowed for systematic coding and retrieval of codes across all transcripts. Interview transcripts were first imported into the software in .docx format. Each transcript was read multiple times to ensure immersion in the data and to identify meaningful units of analysis. The coding process was conducted using a hybrid approach that combined both deductive and inductive strategies: Deductive coding was informed by the study's primary research question: How does the perceived threat of sexual violence affect the psychological well-being and daily behavior of women in urban and semi-urban India? This led to the pre-identification of analytical categories such as fear, anxiety, stress, avoidance, coping strategies, and social isolation, based on the literature and theoretical frameworks such as Trauma Theory and Cognitive Processing Theory.

Inductive coding was used to ensure that novel information and participant-driven themes could emerge organically from the data. This allowed the researchers to capture contextual and culturally embedded dimensions of women's experiences, such as family-imposed curfews, career limitations, and desire for systemic reform. The transcripts were then uploaded into ATLAS.ti by creating a new project and adding the documents to the project folder. Using the open coding function, codes and categories were generated, allowing for the systematic organization of the data. Open coding was conducted in ATLAS.ti using line-by-line analysis for detailed responses

15302415, 2025, 3, Downloaded from https://spssi.onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/asap.70037, Wiley Online Library on [19/01/2026]. See the Terms and Conditions (https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/terms-and-conditions) on Wiley Online Library for rules of use; OA articles are governed by the applicable Creative Commons License

TABLE 1 Themes and sub-themes.

Theme	Sub-themes	Key quotes
Living Under Constant Surveillance	Fear of Public Spaces and Transportation	"I avoid cinema halls and crowded markets"
	Fear of Male Perpetrators	"I avoid going out alone in male-dominated spaces"
Embodied Psychological Distress	Internal experiences (anxiety and depression)	"The fear has contributed to my anxiety, especially when I'm alone"
	Emotional Exhaustion	"The fear can be overwhelming, making it difficult to focus"
Behavioral Modifications and Spatial Withdrawal	Outward behavioral shifts	"I've stopped attending late-night events"
	Altered Daily Routines	"I plan my activities around safety concerns"
Social Regulation and Structural Constraints	External control from family	"My parents won't allow me to go out after 6 p.m."
	Societal Expectations and Career Limitations	"Safety concerns prevent me from taking up night shifts"
Managing Risk and Preserving Dignity	Physical Safety Strategies	"I carry pepper spray and use a safety app"
	Emotional Support and Therapy	"I rely on my support network and mindfulness"
Resistance Through Voice	Demand for Stricter Laws	"There needs to be stronger enforcement of laws against sexual harassment"
	Need for Societal Change	"True change will only come when society respects women as equals"

and paragraph-level coding for extended reflections. Each relevant phrase or sentence was coded as a single unit, and memos were attached to emerging patterns or surprising expressions. As themes began to emerge, the codes were continuously reviewed, merged, or split based on conceptual clarity and relevance to the research question. The data analysis was carried out by the first author. To enhance validity and reduce individual bias, a second researcher reviewed a subset of transcripts and the coding framework. Coding inconsistencies were reviewed and resolved using investigator coordination and reflective discourse to ensure analytic consistency and rigor.

Analytical memos were kept throughout the process to document judgments, record interpretive insights, and keep an eye on how the researcher's stance might have affected the way fragile narratives were interpreted. Iterative consultation was used to refine the final thematic map, and themes were chosen based on theoretical coherence and intensity. The final thematic structure was shaped both by the predefined focus on psychological impact and by themes that organically surfaced from the data, such as family-imposed curfews, career limitations, and desire for legal reform.

ANALYSIS

Table 1 outlines the six core themes that emerged from the analysis. These themes are not just descriptive categories, but conceptually informed information grounded in Trauma Theory (Herman, 1992), Cognitive Processing Theory (Resick & Schnicke, 1992), and feminist perspectives on safety and autonomy.

15302415, 2025, 3, Downloaded from https://spssi.onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/asap.70037, Wiley Online Library on [19/01/2026]. See the Terms and Conditions (https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/terms-and-conditions) on Wiley Online Library for rules of use; OA articles are governed by the applicable Creative Commons License

THEME 1: LIVING UNDER CONSTANT SURVEILLANCE

This theme captures how the perception of public spaces as unsafe leads to a constant state of hypervigilance. Women described feeling watched, judged, and vulnerable, not necessarily because of specific incidents, but because of an internalized sense that danger is always near.

Fear of public spaces and transportation

Participants spoke of a generalized anxiety about being in crowded or male-dominated spaces. For many, this fear was anticipatory, rooted not in personal experience but in collective narratives of violence and a constant internal dialogue about risk. "*I make sure to avoid cinema halls, university gatherings, and any crowded marketplaces. These places make me uncomfortable because of how often harassment occurs there.*" "*Public transport feels risky even if nothing has happened to me directly. It's just the feeling you get when you see how men stare or brush past you.*"

This hypervigilance reflects Trauma Theory's assertion that individuals adapt cognitively to a perceived chronic threat, resulting in a distorted or amplified sense of risk. It also supports feminist perception on how social spaces are differentially experienced by gendered bodies.

Fear of male perpetrators

Rather than specific individuals, the presence of unknown men itself triggered anxiety for participants. This aligns with the idea of ambient fear, a generalized apprehension that emerges from social conditioning like, "*Even if I'm just walking in my own neighborhood, if a group of men are standing nearby, I tense up instantly*" and "*It's not about what's happened, it's about what could happen that's what stays with me.*" These responses show that fear functions not as a reaction, but as a pre-emotive emotional state, shaping women's engagement with their environments before any interaction even occurs.

THEME 2: EMBODIED PSYCHOLOGICAL DISTRESS

Participants often described family-imposed restrictions as "for their safety," yet these controls reinforced societal norms that limit women's freedom. The emotional toll of this persistent fear was manifested in the participants' accounts of anxiety and depression. Women reported being mentally exhausted from the continual need to remain alert and assess their environment for potential threats. This reflects feminist critiques that safety measures can serve as social regulation disguised as care. The emotional toll of living with this ever-present fear manifested in various forms of psychological distress. Participants also described experiencing heightened anxiety, depression, and emotional exhaustion as they grappled with the constant threat of violence.

Internal experience (anxiety and depression)

Several women mentioned that fear of sexual abuse exacerbated their anxiety, making it difficult for them to feel secure even in familiar environments. Another participant explained, "*The fear*

15302415, 2025, 3, Downloaded from https://spssi.onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/asap.70037, Wiley Online Library on [19/01/2026]. See the Terms and Conditions (https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/terms-and-conditions) on Wiley Online Library for rules of use; OA articles are governed by the applicable Creative Commons License

of being assaulted is always in the back of my mind. It has contributed significantly to my anxiety, especially when I am alone." A participant journalist covering women's issues, echoed these concerns: *"As a woman living in a metropolitan city, there's a constant fear. Even the simplest things, like choosing the safest route home, weigh heavily on my mind*."

Emotional exhaustion

The constant state of vigilance and fear took an emotional toll on participants, often leading to feelings of exhaustion and hopelessness. A participant said, "*This fear of something bad happening has drained me. Some days, it's hard to focus on anything because I am overwhelmed by the worry of what might happen*." This emotional burden, compounded by societal expectations and a lack of safety measures, left many women feeling helpless and isolated.

These statements illustrate the cognitive disruptions and emotional overload described by Cognitive Processing Theory (Resick & Schnicke, 1992), in which trauma alters fundamental beliefs about personal safety and control.

THEME 3: BEHAVIOURAL MODIFICATION AND SPATIAL WITHDRAWAL

In contrast to Theme 1's emphasis on perception, this theme focuses on concrete actions women take in response to their fear as how perceived threats translate into restricted behaviors.

OUTWARD BEHAVIOURAL SHIFTS

Participants reported opting out of events, gatherings, or routines that previously formed a normal part of their lives as, "*I've stopped attending late-night gatherings and parties. I'd rather miss out than risk being unsafe*" and "*Even college fests or group outings now seem risky. I just don't feel comfortable anymore*." These are not just safety strategies; they are sacrifices that reflect a broader cost: social isolation, missed opportunities, and diminished autonomy.

ALTERED DAILY ROUTINES

Some participants described altering commutes, clothing, or work schedules. These behaviors are often viewed as "common sense" precautions, but their psychological cost is rarely acknowledged as, "*I plan everything around safety whether it's the time I leave, the route I take, or what I wear*" and "*I always make sure someone knows where I am. I don't go anywhere without checking the area first*." This constant recalibration of daily life reflects a loss of spontaneity and autonomy—not merely out of practicality, but due to deeply internalized fear and societal expectations.

THEME 4: SOCIAL REGULATION AND STRUCTURAL CONSTRAINTS

Family expectations and societal norms played a crucial role in shaping how participants navigated public spaces and their career choices. Women often felt pressure from their

15302415, 2025, 3, Downloaded from https://spssi.onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/asap.70037, Wiley Online Library on [19/01/2026]. See the Terms and Conditions (https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/terms-and-conditions) on Wiley Online Library for rules of use; OA articles are governed by the applicable Creative Commons License

families to adhere to strict safety measures, which sometimes restricted their freedom and opportunities.

External control from family

Many women described how their families-imposed curfews and other restrictions on their movements, often out of concern for their safety. Another participant noted, "*My parents won't allow me to go out after 6 p.m. They're always worried about my safety, and I have to check in constantly to let them know I'm okay*." Other added, "*It's exhausting having to constantly update my family on my whereabouts. They mean well, but it's restricting*."

Societal expectations and career limitations

Societal expectations also played a significant role in limiting women's career options, particularly when it came to jobs requiring travel or late working hours. A participant explained, "*Even though I have the same qualifications as my male colleagues, I'm often overlooked for promotions because of concerns about my safety while commuting or working late*." This imbalance in opportunities only deepened the participants' frustration with societal norms.

This theme reflects how patriarchal norms co-opt the language of safety to enforce traditional gender roles and restrict independence.

THEME 5: MANAGING RISK AND PRESERVING DIGNITY

Despite the overwhelming fear and stress, participants developed coping mechanisms to help manage their anxiety and navigate public spaces with a sense of control. These strategies ranged from physical precautions to emotional support systems.

Physical safety strategies

Many participants described using physical safety tools, such as pepper spray or mobile apps designed to alert others if they felt threatened. A participant shared, "*I never leave the house without my pepper spray, and I've installed an emergency app on my phone that alerts my friends and family if I'm in danger*" and also mentioned attending self-defence classes to feel more empowered.

Emotional support and therapy

Several women turned to their support networks for emotional relief, while others sought professional help. Participant highlighted the importance of staying connected with her friends and family: "*I rely on my support network for emotional support. They help me manage the anxiety that comes with living in fear*." Some participants also mentioned attending therapy sessions to address the emotional toll of constant vigilance.

These efforts reveal how women resist victimization by exercising control over their environment and emotions, an example of adaptive coping mechanisms in trauma contexts.

15302415, 2025, 3, Downloaded from https://spssi.onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/asap.70037, Wiley Online Library on [19/01/2026]. See the Terms and Conditions (https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/terms-and-conditions) on Wiley Online Library for rules of use; OA articles are governed by the applicable Creative Commons License

THEME 6: RESISTANCE THROUGH VOICE

Many participants expressed frustration with the lack of legal and social reforms aimed at protecting women from sexual violence. They emphasized the need for stricter laws, improved safety measures, and widespread societal change.

Demand for stricter laws and law enforcement

Several participants emphasized the need for more stringent laws and stricter enforcement of existing regulations. Participant pointed out, "*There needs to be stronger enforcement of laws against sexual harassment and abuse. Too many perpetrators go unpunished, and that's why the cycle continues*." Many women felt that harsher penalties and faster legal processes would deter potential offenders.

Need for societal change

Participants also spoke about the deep-rooted patriarchal attitudes that perpetuate sexual violence in India. Participant noted, "*True change will only come when society as a whole start respecting women and seeing us as equals. It's not just about laws; it's about shifting the way we think about gender roles*." The desire for a broader cultural shift was evident in many of the interviews, as women recognized that legal reform alone would not be enough to make them feel safe.

This theme reflects the agentic responses women develop in response to systemic injustice and ties to feminist and critical theory's emphasis on structural reform as a form of healing and empowerment.

DISCUSSION

The findings of this study provide a detailed understanding of how the persistent threat of sexual violence impacts women's psychological well-being and everyday behavior in urban and semi-urban India. By integrating Trauma Theory, Cognitive Processing Theory, and feminist theoretical frameworks, this study advances our understanding of fear not merely as an emotional state but as a structural condition deeply embedded in women's lived realities. This study aimed to examine the psychological and behavioral consequences of living under the threat of sexual violence among women in India. While much of the extant literature focuses on survivors of actual sexual assault, this paper focuses on a critical contribution by exploring how the mere anticipation of harm is often based on collective narratives, media accounts, and lived social constraints, which impacts women's psychological well-being and shapes their everyday lives. The findings highlighted how fear becomes internalized, normalized, and systemically reproduced, leading to a state of continuous traumatic stress (CTS), constrained agency, and limited life possibilities.

15302415, 2025, 3, Downloaded from https://spssi.onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/asap.70037, Wiley Online Library on [19/01/2026]. See the Terms and Conditions (https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/terms-and-conditions) on Wiley Online Library for rules of use; OA articles are governed by the applicable Creative Commons License

asap Analyses of Social Issues and Public Policy SPSSI WILEY

Living under constant surveillance

The findings of this study highlight the profound and pervasive impact that the rising incidence of sexual violence in India has on women's perceptions of fear in public spaces. The study shows the persistent fear and hypervigilance reported by participants. (Sur, 2014). Women in the study expressed that fear of sexual abuse deeply permeated their lives, affecting not only their movements in public spaces but also how they interacted with strangers and familiar individuals alike. Public spaces, particularly crowded areas and public transportation, were often avoided due to the perceived threat of harassment or assault. They also described how this fear affects every part of their lives, from moving through public spaces to interacting with strangers or even people they know. This constant alertness and worry, especially with the rising violence in areas like New Delhi and Uttar Pradesh, puts a heavy mental burden on them. This aligns with Trauma Theory's premise that repeated exposure to fear alters a person's perceptual and cognitive processing (Herman, 1992). The quote, "I avoid cinema halls and crowded markets," encapsulates the anticipatory anxiety that transforms ordinary environments into spaces of psychological threat. This finding is also consistent with previous research that shows women living in urban areas of India often experience increased anxiety when moving through public spaces. (Bharucha & Khatri, 2018). This heightened fear leads to behavioral changes, such as avoiding certain locations or only traveling with companions. Women modify their routines and adopt safety strategies to manage the perceived risks, which significantly restricts their freedom of movement and participation in public life. (Neha et al., 2018).

ANTICIPATED HARM AS PSYCHOLOGICAL REALITY

The emotional states described by participants as chronic fear, emotional exhaustion, anxiety, and hypervigilance, which echo the symptoms of trauma as outlined in the Cognitive Processing Theory (Resick & Schnicke, 1992). According to this framework, trauma results in disruptions to cognitive schemas and emotional functioning, even in cases where no direct violence has occurred. Women in this study reported structuring their thoughts and decisions around the possibility of danger, leading to emotional dysregulation and persistent vigilance. The anticipation of harm, rather than the experience itself, becomes central to their psychological world.

These findings support the emerging literature on CTS, a concept first used in conflict zones and now increasingly relevant in urban, gendered contexts. CTS recognizes that trauma can stem from an environment of ongoing or recurring threat, where the stressor has not ended and may never occur but remains plausible. Potluri and Patel (2021), in an Indian adaptation of CTS, emphasized that structural violence, such as caste-based or gender-based oppression, often places individuals in a constant state of alertness. This study echoes that insight, with participants expressing that they constantly anticipate violence, particularly in public spaces, even if they have never personally experienced assault.

> "It's not what has happened; it's what could happen. That's what controls me." – Participant 14

15302415, 2025, 3, Downloaded from https://spssi.onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/asap.70037, Wiley Online Library on [19/01/2026]. See the Terms and Conditions (https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/terms-and-conditions) on Wiley Online Library for rules of use; OA articles are governed by the applicable Creative Commons License

This chronic fear aligns with feminist scholarship, which argues that public patriarchy (Walby, 1990) operates by controlling women's mobility through the threat, not just the act of violence. The fear of the male gaze, potential stalking, harassment, or assault, thus becomes a tool of behavioral governance, regulating women's use of space and time.

EMBODIED VULNERABILITY

The findings of this study highlight significant psychological distress among women who fear or experience sexual violence, aligning with existing research in India. Women's descriptions of anxiety and emotional exhaustion mirror what Cognitive Processing Theory (Resick & Schnicke, 1992) calls schema disruption. When safety is persistently threatened, cognitive frameworks for processing trust, control, and security break down. For example, one participant noted, "It's hard to focus—I feel drained," reflecting not just fear but its long-term cognitive toll. These insights can inform counselling interventions tailored for women experiencing trauma-induced stress symptoms. Participants reported high levels of anxiety and depression due to the constant fear of being assaulted. This echoes findings from Uttar Pradesh, where over 50% of women who faced sexual violence reported anxiety and stress disorders (Rai & Rai, 2020). Emotional exhaustion was a key theme, as women described being overwhelmed by the persistent threat of violence, a pattern also observed in studies linking intimate partner violence with PTSD and depression (Chandra et al., 2009). This research aligns with the previous research on the idea that the psychological effects of sexual violence are long-lasting and severe, with prior studies showing that sexual assault in India often leads to chronic conditions such as anxiety, depression, and suicidal thoughts (Nieder et al., 2019).

THREAT VS. EXPERIENCE: BRIDGING THE CONCEPTUAL DIVIDE

A conceptual challenge in this field is distinguishing between the psychological effects of actual sexual violence and those arising from its persistent threat. For instance, Dokkedahl et al. (2022) conducted a meta-analysis of psychological violence in intimate relationships and found strong correlations between exposure to non-physical threats and the development of PTSD, depression, and anxiety, sometimes even more pronounced than in cases involving physical violence.

Likewise, studies on fear of crime have shown that women's *perceived vulnerability* is often more psychologically damaging than actual victimization (Pain, 1997). This supports the interpretation that emotional responses to potential violence can be as debilitating and life-limiting as responses to direct experience. The current study contributes to this discourse by foregrounding the psychological distress of anticipation, shaped by cultural narratives, gendered expectations, and cumulative warnings.

Everyday recalibrations of safety

This theme showcases how behavioral adaptations, though self-protective, reinforce gendered limitations. Feminist theory critiques these daily compromises as reinforcing the patriarchal

15302415, 2025, 3, Downloaded from https://spssi.onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/asap.70037, Wiley Online Library on [19/01/2026]. See the Terms and Conditions (https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/terms-and-conditions) on Wiley Online Library for rules of use; OA articles are governed by the applicable Creative Commons License

bargain where women adjust their autonomy to maintain perceived safety. Many participants reported restructuring their daily lives to avoid potentially dangerous situations. This included avoiding social gatherings, altering their routes or transportation choices, and limiting their participation in nighttime activities. Avoiding night events or changing routes isn't just behavioral; it's political, reflecting constrained agency. For instance, one participant mentioned that she had stopped attending late-night events due to safety concerns, while others expressed discomfort with public outings, especially in crowded areas (Nieder et al., 2019). This avoidance behavior not only restricted participants' social lives but also contributed to their isolation and feelings of vulnerability. These findings call for public awareness campaigns that reframe safety as a societal, not individual, responsibility.

SOCIAL CONTROL AS PROTECTION

Framed under feminist critiques of patriarchal governance, this theme shows how family-imposed safety measures may serve as tools of social regulation. One participant shared, "My parents won't allow me to go out after 6 p.m.," exemplifying how concern becomes control. This reinforces systemic inequality under the guise of care. Educational programs targeting families and schools should address how restrictive practices curtail women's development and autonomy. The study highlights how family and societal pressures significantly influence how women navigate public spaces and make career choices. Participants reported that family-imposed curfews and restrictions, while intended to keep them safe, often resulted in limiting their freedom and autonomy. This relate to research that shows how familial, social, and cultural factors profoundly shape women's career decisions in India, often limiting their participation in the workforce (Tiwari, 2019). Moreover, societal expectations often limited women's career opportunities, as safety concerns prevented them from accepting jobs requiring travel or late working hours (Parikh, 2018). As societal expectations frequently restricted women from pursuing certain career opportunities, especially those requiring travel or late working hours. Participants expressed that safety concerns prevented them from accepting jobs that involved night shifts or extensive commuting. This dynamic underscore how societal norms can further compound the psychological burden faced by women, trapping them in a cycle of fear and restricted opportunities (Nath, 2000).

Managing risk and preserving dignity

In this theme, women demonstrate resilience through coping mechanisms, such as carrying pepper spray, using safety apps, or seeking emotional support. These strategies align with trauma-informed models of adaptive coping. Despite the overwhelming psychological burden, participants developed various coping mechanisms to navigate their anxiety and fear. Many adopted physical safety strategies, such as carrying pepper spray or using mobile safety apps to alert others in case of danger. One participant mentioned attending self-defence classes to feel more empowered when navigating public spaces. Additionally, several women turned to their support networks for emotional relief, relying on family and friends to help manage the psychological toll of living in constant fear (Nieder et al., 2019). However, while these strategies provided immediate relief, they did not address the deeper emotional and psychological scars inflicted by the pervasive threat of violence.

15302415, 2025, 3, Downloaded from https://spssi.onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/asap.70037, Wiley Online Library on [19/01/2026]. See the Terms and Conditions (https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/terms-and-conditions) on Wiley Online Library for rules of use; OA articles are governed by the applicable Creative Commons License

Resistance through voice

Participants' calls for policy reform and societal change represent a refusal to remain passive. Their narratives align with feminist and critical theory's emphasis on agency and transformation. Statements like, "True change will only come when society respects women," underscore the demand for justice, not just protection.

Participants expressed a strong desire for legal and societal reforms to address the root causes of sexual violence and its psychological impact. Many emphasized the need for stricter law enforcement, noting that current regulations did little to deter perpetrators of sexual violence. A participant stated that more stringent laws and harsher penalties would help break the cycle of violence and reduce the fear that women experience daily. Beyond legal reforms, participants also called for broader societal changes, including a shift in gender norms and attitudes toward women. They argued that true safety could only be achieved when society respected women as equals and rejected patriarchal structures that perpetuated violence against them . This aligns with broader calls for reform, as seen in studies advocating for a human rights-based approach to reforming sexual offence laws in India, addressing systemic gender-based violence, and ensuring justice for victims (Bronitt & Misra, 2017). Similarly, the 2012 Delhi rape case has been widely recognized as a catalyst for public discussions on legal and social reforms aimed at improving women's safety and addressing socio-economic inequalities that perpetuate gender violence (Kumar, 2014).

BEHAVIOURAL GOVERNANCE AND STRUCTURAL CONSTRAINTS

Themes in this study also revealed how psychological fear translates into concrete behavioral modifications when women avoided public spaces, declined professional opportunities, and restricted social interactions. These actions are not irrational responses but adaptive strategies in an environment that structurally positions women as vulnerable.

This behavioral adaptation is reinforced by social regulation, particularly through family restrictions and moral surveillance. Participants reported being subject to curfews, dress codes, and gendered advice from both family and peers. This is consistent with Bourdieu's concept of symbolic violence, where control is exerted not through overt force, but through culturally accepted norms (Creaney & Burns, 2023).

The Protection of Women from Domestic Violence Act (PWDVA), 2005, further supports the argument that threats constitute real harm. The Act defines abuse to include not only physical acts but also emotional and psychological threats (Government of India, 2005). While the law typically applies to domestic contexts, its principles can inform broader policies that acknowledge the pervasive psychological harm caused by societal threats of violence.

Lastly, the findings not only map the psychological impact of fear but also highlight the socio-political structures that maintain it. Future work should explore how intersecting factors like caste, religion, and socio-economic status shape these experiences further, and how targeted interventions can break the cycle of fear and restriction.

LIMITATION AND RECOMMENDATIONS

The small sample size and geographic focus on Delhi NCR and Uttar Pradesh may limit the generalizability of the findings to other regions of India. However, considering the pervasive nature

15302415, 2025, 3, Downloaded from https://spssi.onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/asap.70037, Wiley Online Library on [19/01/2026]. See the Terms and Conditions (https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/terms-and-conditions) on Wiley Online Library for rules of use; OA articles are governed by the applicable Creative Commons License

of sexual violence nationwide, women in other regions are likely to experience similar psychological impacts. This study primarily focused on fear and anxiety related to sexual violence, but other factors such as socio-economic status, caste, and cultural norms also deserve further exploration for a more comprehensive understanding of the issue.

Future research should expand to include other regions of India, particularly rural and less urbanized areas, to capture a broader range of psychological impacts. Longitudinal studies are necessary to track how fear, anxiety, and coping mechanisms evolve over time. Additionally, socio-economic status, caste, and cultural norms should be investigated further to deepen understanding of how these factors influence the psychological consequences of sexual violence.

CONCLUSION

Sexual violence has a profound and far-reaching psychological impact on women, particularly in regions like Delhi NCR and Uttar Pradesh. The constant threat of harassment and assault leads to persistent fear, anxiety, and stress, which deeply influence women's mental health and everyday lives. As the findings show, many women alter their behaviors and routines to cope with this fear, leading to isolation, hypervigilance, and emotional distress. Coping strategies vary but often fall short of addressing the deeper psychological scars left by the ongoing threat of violence.

The paper highlights not only the immediate effects of sexual violence but also the broader societal pressures that exacerbate these experiences. Factors such as family restrictions, societal norms, and career limitations play a significant role in shaping women's responses to these threats. The discussion emphasizes the need for further research that explores how socio-economic status, caste, and cultural expectations influence the psychological consequences of sexual violence.

AUTHOR CONTRIBUTIONS

Conceptualization: Afreen Waseem. *Methodology*: Afreen Waseem and Naila Firdous. *Formal analysis*: Afreen Waseem, Naila Firdous, and Shah Alam. *Investigation*: Afreen Waseem, Naila Firdous, and Shah Alam. *Resources*: Afreen Waseem and Naila Firdous. *Data management*: Afreen Waseem and Naila Firdous. *Writing – original draft preparation*: Afreen Waseem. *Writing – review and editing*: Afreen Waseem, Naila Firdous, and Shah Alam. *Visualization*: Shah Alam. *Supervision*: Shah Alam. *Project administration*: Afreen Waseem. All authors have read and agreed to the published version of the manuscript.

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

The authors would like to thank all the participants who generously shared their experiences and made this research possible. We are also grateful to our colleagues at Aligarh Muslim University for their valuable feedback and support throughout the research process. Informed consent was obtained digitally before the interview, and participants were reminded of their right to withdraw at any point.

CONFLICT OF INTEREST STATEMENT

The authors declare no conflicts of interest.

15302415, 2025, 3, Downloaded from https://spssi.onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/asap.70037, Wiley Online Library on [19/01/2026]. See the Terms and Conditions (https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/terms-and-conditions) on Wiley Online Library for rules of use; OA articles are governed by the applicable Creative Commons License

DATA AVAILABILITY STATEMENT

The data supporting the findings of this study are available from the corresponding author upon reasonable request.

ORCID

Afreen Waseem https://orcid.org/0009-0002-1743-852X

REFERENCES

Amone-P'Olak, K., Elklit, A., & Dokkedahl, S. B. (2018). PTSD, mental illness, and care among survivors of sexual violence in Northern Uganda: Findings from the WAYS study. *Psychological Trauma: Theory, Research, Practice, and Policy*, *10*(3), 282–289. https://doi.org/10.1037/tra0000295

Antonsdóttir, H. F. (2020). Injustice disrupted: Experiences of just spaces by victim-survivors of sexual violence. *Social & Legal Studies*, *29*(5), 718–744. https://doi.org/10.1177/0964663919896065

Banerjea, N. (2019). Being queer feminists in Delhi: Narratives of (non) belonging. *Geography Research Forum*, *39*, 90–105.

Bharucha, J., & Khatri, R. (2018). The sexual street harassment battle: Perceptions of women in urban India. *The Journal of Adult Protection*, *20*(2), 101–109. https://doi.org/10.1108/JAP-12-2017-0038

Bhattacharyya, R. (2016). Understanding the spatialities of sexual assault against Indian women in India. *Gender, Place & Culture*, *23*(1), 134–147. https://doi.org/10.1080/0966369X.2014.969684

Braun, V., & Clarke, V. (2019). Reflecting on reflexive thematic analysis. *Qualitative research in sport, exercise and health*, *11*(4), 589–597. https://doi.org/10.1080/2159676x.2019.1628806

Bronitt, S., & Misra, A. (2017). Reforming sexual offences in India: Lessons in human rights and comparative law. *Griffith Asia Quarterly*, *21*, 37–56.

Chandra, P. S., Satyanarayana, V. A., & Carey, M. P. (2009). Women reporting intimate partner violence in India: Associations with PTSD and depressive symptoms. *Archives of Women's Mental Health*, *12*(4), 203–209. https://doi.org/10.1007/s00737-009-0065-6

Chatterjee, P. (2020). Empowering women in India through education and skill development. *International Journal of Research in Social Sciences*, *10*(2), 62–74.

Creaney, S., & Burns, S. (2023). Freedom from symbolic violence? Facilitators and barriers to participatory practices in youth justice. *Youth Justice*, *24*(1), 31–52. https://doi.org/10.1177/14732254231156844

Desai, S., & Andrist, L. (2010). Gender scripts and age at marriage in India. *Demography*, *47*(3), 667–687. https://doi.org/10.1353/dem.0.0118

Dokkedahl, S. B., Kirubakaran, R., Bech-Hansen, D., Kristensen, T. R., & Elklit, A. (2022). The psychological subtype of intimate partner violence and its effect on mental health: A systematic review with meta-analyses. *Systematic Reviews*, *11*, 163. https://doi.org/10.1186/s13643-022-02025-z

Government of India. (2005). *Protection of Women from Domestic Violence Act, 2005* (Act No. 43 of 2005). Chapter I, Section 3. Retrieved from Indian Kanoon.

Hanson, R. K. (1990). The psychological impact of sexual assault on women and children: A review. *Sexual Abuse: A Journal of Research and Treatment*, *3*(2), 187–232. https://doi.org/10.1177/107906329000300204

Herman, J. L. (1992). *Trauma and recovery: The aftermath of violence—from domestic abuse to political terror*. Basic Books.

Huang, X. Y., West, E., & Pinnelli, S. S. K. (2023). Crowdsourcing data for safer travel experiences for women in India. Extended Abstracts of the 2023 CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems. *Association for Computing Machinery*, 1–6. https://doi.org/10.1145/3544549.3583836

Ison, J., Forsdike, K., Henry, N., Hooker, L., & Taft, A. (2023). "You're just constantly on alert": Women and gender-diverse people's experiences of sexual violence on public transport. *Journal of Interpersonal Violence*, *38*(21–22), 11617–11641.

Kalokhe, A. S., Potdar, R. R., Stephenson, R., Dunkle, K. L., Paranjape, A., Del Rio, C., & Sahay, S. (2015). How well does the World Health Organization definition of domestic violence work for India? *PLoS ONE*, *10*(3), e0120909. https://doi.org/10.1371/journal.pone.0120909

15302415, 2025, 3, Downloaded from https://spssi.onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/asap.70037, Wiley Online Library on [19/01/2026]. See the Terms and Conditions (https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/terms-and-conditions) on Wiley Online Library for rules of use; OA articles are governed by the applicable Creative Commons License

Kumar, P., & Parkash, R. (2020). Is rape crime or curse: Issues, challenges and management. *International Journal of Indian Psychology*, *8*(4), 118–128. https://doi.org/10.25215/0804.017

McDonald, C., & Martinez, K. (2019). Victim narratives of sibling emotional abuse. *Child Welfare*, *97*(2), 1–22. https://doi.org/10.2307/48623641

Mehra, D., Srivastava, S., Chandra, M., Srivastava, N., Laaksonen, M., Saarinen, H. E., & Mehra, S. (2023). Effect of physical mobility, decision making and economic empowerment on gender-based violence among married youth in India—SAWERA project. *BMC Public Health [Electronic Resource]*, *23*(1), 548. https://doi.org/10.1186/s12889-023-15421-4

Moscarello, R. (1990). Psychological management of victims of sexual assault. *The Canadian Journal of Psychiatry*, *35*(1), 25–30. https://doi.org/10.1177/070674379003500104

Nath, D. (2000). Gently shattering the glass ceiling: Experiences of Indian women managers. *Women in Management Review*, *15*(1), 44–52. https://doi.org/10.1108/09649420010310191

Neha, J. P., Prasad, P., Cowie, S. M., Gatha, S., & Overland, T. (2018). Safe spaces for women to be physically active in Greater Noida City, India. *Advances in Environmental Studies*, *2*(2), 209–214. https://doi.org/10.36959/742/209

Nieder, C., Muck, C., & Kärtner, J. (2019). Sexual violence against women in India: Daily life and coping strategies of young women in Delhi. *Violence Against Women*, *25*(14), 1717–1738. https://doi.org/10.1177/1077801218824056

Nolin, M.-C., Bőthe, B., Bergeron, S., Godbout, N., Daspe, M.-È., & Vaillancourt-Morel, M.-P. (2023). Social reactions to disclosure of sexual violence in adulthood and women's sexuality: The mediating role of shame and guilt. *Journal of Sex & Marital Therapy*, *49*(3), 270–286. https://doi.org/10.1080/0092623X.2022.2099495

Pain, R. H. (1997). Whither women's fear? Perceptions of sexual violence in public and private space. *International Review of Victimology*, *4*(4), 297–312. https://doi.org/10.1177/026975809700400404

Parikh, A. (2018). Politics of presence: Women's safety and respectability at night in Mumbai, India. *Gender, Place & Culture*, *25*(5), 695–710. https://doi.org/10.1080/0966369X.2017.1400951

Phadke, S. (2007). Dangerous liaisons: Women and men: Risk and reputation in Mumbai. *Economic and Political Weekly*, *42*(17), 1510–1518.

Pooja, B. S., Guddattu, V., & Rao, K. A. (2024). Crime against women in India: District-level risk estimation using the small area estimation approach. *Frontiers in Public Health*, *12*, Article 1362406. https://doi.org/10.3389/fpubh.2024.1362406

Potluri, S., & Patel, A. R. (2021). Using a continuous traumatic stress framework to examine ongoing adversity among Indian women from slums: A mixed-methods exploration. *Journal of Traumatic Stress*, *34*(5), 917–928. https://doi.org/10.1002/jts.22699

Pryor, D. W., & Hughes, M. R. (2013). Fear of rape among college women: A social psychological analysis. *Violence and Victims*, *28*(3), 443–465. https://doi.org/10.1891/0886-6708.VV-D-12-00029

Quing, K. A. (2021). I am a survivor: Experiences, impacts and coping mechanisms of Filipino victims of sexual violence. *Journal of Education, Management and Development Studies*, *1*(1), 50–65. https://doi.org/10.52631/jemds.v1i1.18

Rai, R., & Rai, A. K. (2020). Sexual violence and poor mental health of women: An exploratory study of Uttar Pradesh, India. *Clinical Epidemiology and Global Health*, *8*(1), 194–198. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.cegh.2019.06.013

Resick, P. A., & Schnicke, M. K. (1992). Cognitive processing therapy for sexual assault victims. *Journal of Consulting and Clinical Psychology*, *60*(5), 748–756. https://doi.org/10.1037/0022-006X.60.5.748

Riger, S., & Gordon, M. T. (1981). The fear of rape: A study in social control. *Journal of Social Issues*, *37*(4), 71–92. https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1540-4560.1981.tb01071.x

Sharma, K., & Gupta, P. (2020). Patriarchy and backlash: A study on gender-based violence in India. *Indian Journal of Gender Studies*, *27*(3), 353–372.

Simon-Kumar, R. (2014). Sexual violence in India: The discourses of rape and the discourses of justice. *Indian Journal of Gender Studies*, *21*(3), 451–460. https://doi.org/10.1177/0971521514540711

Souza, F. B. C. D., Drezett, J., Meirelles, A. D. C., & Ramos, D. G. (2012). Aspectos psicológicos de mulheres que sofrem violência sexual. *Reprodução & Climatério*, *27*(3), 98–103. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.recli.2013.03.002

Stark, J., & Meschik, M. (2018). Women's everyday mobility: Frightening situations and their impacts on travel behavior. *Transportation Research Part F: Traffic Psychology and Behaviour*, *59*, 311–321.

Sur, P. (2014). Safety in the urban outdoors: Women negotiating fear of crime in the city of Kolkata. *Gender, Technology and Development*, *15*(2), 243–267.

15302415, 2025, 3, Downloaded from https://spssi.onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/asap.70037, Wiley Online Library on [19/01/2026]. See the Terms and Conditions (https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/terms-and-conditions) on Wiley Online Library for rules of use; OA articles are governed by the applicable Creative Commons License

Tiwari, H. (2019). Encounters with gendered realities in career decision-making while scouting women participation in the Indian workforce. *Business Perspectives and Research*, *7*(2), 147–162. https://doi.org/10.1177/2278533719833814

Tripathi, P. (2023). Cartographies of sexual violence from Delhi to Hathras: An intersectional feminist understanding. *Gender, Place & Culture*, *30*(7), 946–968. https://doi.org/10.1080/0966369X.2022.2085674

Vindhya, U. (2020). Feminist psychologies in India. In *Oxford research encyclopaedia of psychology*. Oxford UniversityPress. https://doi.org/10.1093/acrefore/9780190236557.013.826

Walby, S. (1990). *Theorizing patriarchy*. Blackwell.

How to cite this article: Waseem, A., Firdous, N., & Alam, S. (2025). Living in fear: The psychological impact of the threat of sexual violence on women in India. *Analyses of Social Issues and Public Policy*, *25*, e70037. https://doi.org/10.1111/asap.70037

AUTHOR BIOGRAPHIES

Afreen Waseem is an assistant professor in the Department of Applied Psychology at GITAM University. She holds a PhD degree from Aligarh Muslim University, a Diploma in Counselling Psychology from Jamia Millia Islamia, and a Master's in Psychology from Aligarh Muslim University. Her research interests include the psychological impact of emotional abuse on adolescents, self-concept, adjustment, ADHD, and resilience.

Naila Firdous is a Research Scholar in the Department of Psychology at Aligarh Muslim University, India. She holds a PhD degree from Aligarh Muslim University and a Master's in Psychology from Aligarh Muslim University. Her research interests focus on the psychological effects of social issues, parenting style including the impact of violence and trauma on mental health.

Shah Alam is a Professor in the Department of Psychology at Aligarh Muslim University, pursuing his Ph.D. in psychology. He holds a PhD degree from and a Master's in Psychology from Aligarh Muslim University. His research interests include adolescence, mental health, self-efficacy, life skills, emotional abuse and parenting style.

15302415, 2025, 3, Downloaded from https://spssi.onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/asap.70037, Wiley Online Library on [19/01/2026]. See the Terms and Conditions (https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/terms-and-conditions) on Wiley Online Library for rules of use; OA articles are governed by the applicable Creative Commons License